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Memorial in Newburg to be dedicated to veteran service dogs

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Larry Abel, left, Brian Piaquadio and Julie Muster Bryson pose with Chewy at the Maryland Veterans Museum.
Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

Brian Piaquadio was not an animal person.

But five years ago, a Veterans Affairs doctor recommended he get a service dog after two decades as a Marine veteran.

“It’s been life changing,” Piaquadio said. “He’s my constant ever companion.”

Chewy was meant to be his wife’s dog but since Chewy was already attached to Piaquadio, he got the dog trained at Semper K9 Assistance Dogs in Quantico, Va. For five years, Chewy has been with Piaquadio in public places and in his passenger seat on his motorcycle.

Chewy is trained to pick up and retrieve things and alert Piaquadio’s wife if he falls down. However, a service dog can also help a combat veteran who suffers from post-traumatic stress disorder and who does not like to be in public or around large crowds.

“It was probably 20 years before I realized I had something with PTSD,” Piaquadio said. “I just figured I was just a grumpy, hurt veteran.”

Dogs have short lives, Piaquadio said. He noticed how other veterans interact with their service dogs. Many veterans are on their second or third service dog, “but there’s always that one that means more than all the rest.”

However, there has not been a place to memorialize service dogs like there is for police and military dogs, Piaquadio said.

He met Julie Muster Bryson, the founder of Boots 2 Benefits and a U.S. Army veteran at a Charles County commissioners’ meeting. Together, they started planning a memorial site for veteran service dogs at the Maryland Veterans Museum in Newburg.

“These animals are miraculous,” Bryson said. “There are veterans that would not leave their house unless they had a service dog.”

In 2022, veterans had a suicide rate of 34.7 per 100,000 veterans compared 17.1 per 100,000 non-veterans, according to the 2024 National Veteran Suicide Prevention Annual Report.

“Back when I served, you never talked about having issues or troubles,” Bryson said. “Now it’s a very open communicative thing.”

Bryson does not have official service dogs, but her two pet dogs go everywhere with her because she has anxiety when she goes out in public. Other family members suffer from PTSD and benefit from having a service dog, she said.

Service dogs for veterans can lower PTSD symptoms, anxiety and depression after as little as three months of intervention, according to a 2024 study from the National Institutes of Health.

“That dog can be that buffer and can be trained to sense when stress is coming on a veteran,” Piaquadio said. “It’s just amazing [what] these different dogs [are] being able to do for each one of the veterans.”

The team involved in the memorial has been working on getting funding and setting up partnerships to make it possible. Piaquadio and Bryson are working with Three Little Birds Outdoor Living and Sutton Betti, who will create a sculpture of Chewy for the memorial.

The Maryland Veterans Museum is planning to create a memorial garden for the “unsung heroes” that would include service dogs, Larry Abel, president of the museum, said.

“The idea is that many of these groups [are] more than just Charles County,” Abel said. “All of this is bigger than any of us.”
